reaching out to Pakistan. In the quarter century thereafter, Indo-Soviet relations had developed, as indeed had Sino-Pakistan ties and Sino-US collaboration. At first glance, a balance appeared to have been reached by the mid-1970s that now allowed forward movement between India and China. But rather than allow a natural equilibrium to set in, China made a policy move that was no ordinary one. What it did has been rightly described as the ‘ultimate gift’ one nation can give to another in modern times.

The assistance to make nuclear weapons had been extended till then only by the US to the UK, the USSR to China (before ending it half-way), and France to Israel. This short list highlights how rarely this option had till then been exercised in international relations, obviously for good reasons. The logic of the Chinese move now was in consonance with the 1963 objective – to keep Pakistan hyphenated to India. But the act carries such a premium that it answers the query of how much India really counts in Chinese calculations.

Its impact on policy and public attitudes in India were to be profound. Significantly, Sino-Pakistani nuclear collaboration starts around the time India and China revived ambassadorial-level ties between them. This compulsion by the more powerful partner to assuage the concerns of the weaker one has remained a persistent strain in Chinese thinking about Pakistan. As this tie-up assumed serious proportions, China’s nuclear technology was transferred to that country even as Sino-Indian boundary negotiations picked up. The pattern continued, and the Rajiv Gandhi visit was followed by the transfer of missiles. There were even rumours of a nuclear test conducted for Pakistan by China on its soil. The story carries on and the entry of North Korea as a third party only added to its complex texture.

This set of legacy issues is a cross that Sino-Indian relations carry to this day. They not only shaped the past but remain factors that affect the present and the future. Being in denial of their implications serves little purpose. Those committed to taking forward ties must accept these realities and work through them in the interest of a larger goal. It is only by confronting a difficult history honestly that it can be really set to rest.